

From Self to AI Afterlife: Exploring Identity Work Transcending Death

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The rapid advancement of generative AI has given rise to the concept of AI Afterlife, where digital agents simulate individuals and extend their presence beyond death. AI Afterlife enables generation, interaction, and even ongoing evolution. This dynamic nature presents both opportunities and challenges in maintaining identity continuity and coherence. However, there is limited understanding of how individuals engage in identity work that transcends death within the context of AI Afterlife. In this paper, we present a qualitative study examining three dimensions of identity work: crafting, continuing, and relating identity. Our results uncover how identity is crafted through reflection and curation, continued through presentation, flexibility, evolution, and avoidance, and related to relational uniqueness and scaffolding. We further conceptualize identity in AI Afterlife as negotiated, dynamic, and relational, and adapt narrative identity to posthumous AI-mediated contexts. Finally, we propose design implications and ethical considerations for supporting identity work in AI Afterlife.

CCS Concepts: • **Human-centered computing** → **Empirical studies in HCI**.

Additional Key Words and Phrases: AI Afterlife, Digital Legacy, Identity, Narrative Identity, Generative AI

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1 Introduction

Generative AI has advanced rapidly, enabling the creation of realistic agents modeled after specific individuals [1, 15, 43, 58, 76]. Building on this development, scholars have begun to explore the emerging idea of *AI Afterlife*, which refers to using AI-generated agents to simulate individuals for posthumous purposes [44, 55]. It aims to enable people to maintain a presence beyond death and foster ongoing emotional bonds with loved ones [44]. Compared to other forms of remembrance [13], AI Afterlife is generative, interactive, and even evolving [44]. Yet, as the core objective of AI Afterlife is to represent the person, these very qualities also bring identity to the forefront as a central challenge [44].

Identity is broadly defined as the construction of a coherent and purposeful self-concept [16–18]. In post-mortem contexts, identity is often reflected through the attributes of the deceased embedded in digital legacies [13]. These legacies may be intentionally curated, through life stories and values contained in private archives [7, 21, 44, 64], or unintentionally left behind, such as implicit traces embedded in social media profiles [26]. Prior research highlights both the motivations and concerns behind crafting identity in traditional digital legacies, including the desire to preserve personal stories and values as well as anxieties about misrepresentation and loss of control [10, 13, 26].

While some insights derived from traditional digital legacies can be extended to the context of AI Afterlife, its unique features of generating new information, interacting with others, and even evolving over time [44] introduce distinctive opportunities and challenges for identity. First, extending identity beyond life through AI Afterlife opens up new possibilities for identity reflection and curation, as it allows individuals not only to preserve their past but

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also to shape how their values, narratives, and relationships are carried forward. Second, without careful negotiation and alignment with technological capabilities, the continuity and coherence of one's projected identity risk being undermined. However, little is known about how people will construct, negotiate, and sustain their identities, a process referred to as *identity work* [6, 36, 66], in this emerging context. Addressing this gap is crucial for researchers, designers, and developers to better harness the potential of AI Afterlife to support the continuity and coherence of identity.

To advance this understanding, we examine how people engage in identity work that transcends death within the context of AI Afterlife. Specifically, we investigate three research questions:

- **RQ1:** How do individuals reflect upon and curate a coherent sense of self within the context of AI Afterlife?
- **RQ2:** How do individuals envision projecting and sustaining this identity through such technologies?
- **RQ3:** How is identity work shaped by relational dynamics, given that AI Afterlife inherently involves ongoing interaction with others?

We explored these questions through semi-structured interviews with 14 participants (aged 20-79) from diverse backgrounds across China. While AI Afterlife could take various forms (e.g., visual or embodied interaction), this study focuses on conversational chatbots, where interaction is primarily mediated through language. This focus foregrounds identity construction through narrative expression, while setting aside multimodal cues for future exploration.

In particular, our study is informed by the psychological concept of *narrative identity* [48]. It posits that people construct identity by integrating life experiences into an evolving life story, through selectively reconstructing the past and imaginatively projecting the future within interpersonal and sociocultural contexts. This notion naturally resonates with the aims of AI Afterlife, which seeks to preserve and extend one's sense of self beyond death. It thus provides a useful lens for examining how individuals craft and continue identity in AI Afterlife, especially in relation to others.

Our findings underscore the complex and multifaceted nature of identity within the context of AI Afterlife. Identity is *crafted* through reflection and curation practices, and *continued* through ongoing negotiations involving presentation, flexibility, evolution, and avoidance. It is also inherently *relational*, shaped by diverse access and narrative, formed and sustained through relational scaffolding. Based on these findings, we conceptualize identity in AI Afterlife as negotiated, dynamic, and relational, and suggest that narrative identity could be adapted in posthumous AI-mediated contexts. We further propose design implications for supporting identity work in future AI Afterlife systems, and conclude by outlining ethical considerations to ensure responsible identity work.

This paper contributes to the HCI community by: (1) presenting an empirical investigation of how identity is crafted, continued, and relationally shaped in AI Afterlife; (2) applying and extending the concept of narrative identity in posthumous AI-mediated contexts; and (3) offering design implications for supporting identity work in AI Afterlife.

2 Related Work

In this section, we situate our work within three strands of literature. We begin with digital legacy and AI Afterlife, then review prior work on identity in digital legacy, and finally turn to narrative identity as our theoretical lens.

2.1 Digital Legacy and AI Afterlife

Legacy materials refer to items passed down by the deceased to bereaved loved ones [13], encompassing intangible elements such as values, wishes, and identities, as well as tangible and digital artifacts. As everyday life becomes increasingly digitized, digital legacy, the collection of one's digital assets including social media accounts [22, 57], passwords [19, 33], and personal media [59], has become a growing area of interest in HCI. Researchers have extensively

examined digital legacy practices over the past decades. A recent review by Doyle and Brubaker categorized this work into four areas [13]: (1) digital legacy as reflections of identity [28, 40, 71]; (2) user engagement with digital legacy [7, 21, 45]; (3) practices and implications of laying digital content to rest [26, 38, 41]; and (4) integrating technologies into traditional legacy practices [56, 72, 73]. This body of work has primarily examined static digital traces left behind after death, central to memorialization but limited in their ability to capture dynamic, ongoing identity.

With the rapid advancement of generative AI [1, 43, 58, 76, 77], researchers have begun to explore the emerging idea of AI Afterlife, defined as AI-generated agents that simulate individuals for post-mortem purposes [44, 55]. Unlike traditional digital legacy, these agents are generative, interactive, and dynamic, offering both self continuation and even extension [44, 55]. Initial efforts in this field have primarily focused on bereaved individuals creating agents modeled after the deceased to aid in grieving and emotional comfort [1, 4, 11, 24, 62]. Recent developments, however, reflect a growing interest in people creating their own AI Afterlives while alive, as a way to continue their presence and preserve emotional bonds [2, 3, 44, 55, 68]. One related work on AI Afterlife explored people's perceptions, expectations, and concerns about this emerging digital legacy [44]. While this study highlighted the importance of identity consistency, it did not provide a comprehensive account of how people engage in identity work within AI Afterlife. Moreover, existing research and products (e.g., HereAfter [3], StoryFile [68]) focus primarily on preserving digital legacy, often resulting in generic interactions that overlook contextual and relational dynamics [39]. Our work addresses this gap by moving beyond concerns of identity consistency to uncover the broader practices of identity work, examining how people envision crafting and continuing identity in AI Afterlife, with relational considerations.

2.2 Identity in Digital Legacy

Digital legacies inherently embed aspects of identity of the deceased [13], whether curated intentionally [7, 21, 64] or unintentionally [26]. These materials range from memorial pages and private archives [7, 21, 64] to undeleted social media profiles and abandoned accounts that persist by default [26, 29, 54]. While such persistence enables continued representation and memorialization [28, 59, 71], it also raises challenges around identity persistence and control [26].

When digital legacies are intentionally curated, people often aim to shape what will be remembered [27], ensuring the continuation of their major life events and personal stories [27, 38]. Many also seek to pass on values, knowledge, and even provide practical assistance to have positive impacts on future generations [26, 27, 44]. Such curation practices become more salient when facing aging, illness, or bereavement [10, 33, 59], where legacy serves as a way of continuing identity. Digital legacy thus not only sustains one's projected self but also shapes the impact one leaves after death.

However, the persistence of identity also raises concerns. Unintentional digital traces, such as abandoned accounts or uncensored social media content, may misrepresent how individuals wish to be remembered [26, 29]. Even with intentional curation, individuals express anxieties about maintaining control, both over posthumous self-representation [10] and over the potential unintended consequences of digital legacy [71]. For example, people worry about misinterpretation of their identity [26] or inadequate reflection of sociocultural dimensions [28]. Control of access is another central issue, with concerns over privacy, identity theft, and the erasure or overexposure of personal meaning. These risks threaten to undermine individuals' agency in shaping how their identity is represented after death. [71].

Building on these insights, our study extends prior work by examining identity work in AI Afterlife, an emerging form of digital legacy that enables generating new information, reacting to people and the environment, and even evolving over time. While opening up richer representation possibilities, it also brings risks to the consistency of identity [44]. We extend this inquiry by examining how users envision crafting and continuing identity in such AI-mediated context, particularly in relation to others.

2.3 Theoretical Background: Narrative Identity

Narrative identity builds on Erikson’s conception of identity as the construction of a coherent and purposeful self-concept [16, 18]. McAdams extended this idea through the life story theory, defining narrative identity as “an internalized and evolving story of the self” that individuals construct to make sense of their lives across time [46, 48]. This involves both selective reconstructions of the autobiographical past and imaginative projections into the future, providing unity and purpose for the self and in relation to others [48]. While narrative identity typically begins to form in adolescence [30], it remains fluid through life course [47, 51], shaped by ongoing personal development [52] and deeply embedded within interpersonal and sociocultural contexts [50, 63]. Meanwhile, later developments of this theory highlight its multiplicity and performativity [32, 49, 52], emphasizing that narrative identity is not merely a single coherent “big story”, but often constituted through “small stories” emerging in everyday conversations and localized contexts [53].

The concept of narrative identity and its associated research methods have been widely applied in fields such as personality, clinical, and cognitive psychology [65]. Singer described the emergence of a new generation of researchers coalescing around narrative identity, characterized by shared commitments: a cognitive approach to autobiographical memory, attention to sociocultural influences on identity, a life-span developmental perspective, and openness to multimethod inquiry [65]. In HCI, narrative identity has informed studies that treat users as story-makers whose identities are shaped, sustained, or reconstructed through their interactions with technology, such as social media [14, 31], and AI writing assistant [75]. For instance, Haimson and Marathe developed a method to support reflection on identity transitions by visualizing the sentiment embedded in participants’ social media data [31].

In our context, narrative identity first informs us when exploring identity crafting work, where people selectively reconstruct the past and imaginatively project into the future within the contexts of AI Afterlife. Moreover, posthumous contexts mediated by AI Afterlife represents an emerging narrative space of identity that transcends death, where narrative identity is under-explored. Given that narrative identity is always embedded within interpersonal and sociocultural contexts, it further informs our focus on relational dynamics within identity work in AI Afterlife.

3 Method

In this section, we outline the methods used in designing and conducting this qualitative study. Throughout the study, we consistently apply the definition of AI Afterlife (see section 1), with a particular focus on its posthumous purposes and the intention of representing the self, not others. While AI Afterlife can take multiple forms of presentation [44, 55], our study primarily focused on the technical form of a conversational chatbot. We made this choice to foreground identity construction through narrative expression [48], as conversational interaction highlights how the self can be narrated, negotiated, and sustained through language. Other multimodal cues, such as tone of voice, visual design, or embodied interaction, are acknowledged as important for identity expression, but were set aside for future exploration (see section 6).

3.1 Participants: Inclusion Criteria and Recruitment

To surface nuanced understandings of how people craft and continue identity in such speculative scenarios, we sought participants with lived experiences and motivations that could meaningfully inform this design space [10, 13, 44]. Eligible participants met one or more of the following criteria: (1) those who had experienced major health-related events, aging, or life disruptions, which may prompt reflection on legacy and continuation; (2) those who had lost close family or friends, and considered or engaged with posthumous remembrance; (3) professionals or practitioners working

in healthcare, psychology, social work, or AI that are familiar with death, legacy, or digital human; and (4) people who regularly practice personal narrative and reflection (e.g., journaling) and show interest in using AI for self-expression. These criteria foregrounded participants with reflective insight and contextual relevance to enrich our study.

We recruited participants primarily through personal social networks, social media groups, and snowball sampling [23]. The recruitment process began with the personal networks of authors and outreach through relevant online groups. Participants were invited to recommend family members or acquaintances who matched the inclusion criteria, following the snowball sampling method. To ensure diversity, we included participants across a range of demographic characteristics, including gender, age, location, health status, education, occupation, AI literacy, and relevant experiences.

After receiving IRB approval, we conducted interviews until reaching thematic saturation [25]. In total, we interviewed 14 participants (8 female, 6 male), aged 20-79 and distributed in 8 different provinces across China. Their health backgrounds varied from healthy to those with recent critical illness or chronic conditions. Participants also represented a range of education and occupation background, AI literacy, and related experience. To balance transparency and privacy, Table 1 selectively presents key demographic variables that are most pertinent to our study.

Table 1. Demographic information of participants. Rel. exp. means participants' related experience. Type 1 means those who had experienced major health-related events, aging, or life disruptions; type 2 means those who had experienced bereavement; type 3 means people studying or working in related fields; type 4 means people regularly practicing personal narrative and reflection.

ID	Gender	Age	Education	Occupation / Specialty	AI Literacy	Rel. exp.
P1	Male	20-29	PhD student	Computer Science	Advanced	type3
P2	Male	20-29	Master student	Psychology	Intermediate	type3
P3	Female	40-49	Associate's	Business Operator	Beginner	type1, 2
P4	Male	20-29	Master student	Medicine	Intermediate	type3, 4
P5	Female	50-59	Bachelor's	Doctor	Beginner	type2, 3, 4
P6	Female	60-69	Associate's	Designer	Novice	type1, 2
P7	Male	70-79	Basic	Worker	Beginner	type1, 2
P8	Female	60-69	Associate's	Accountant	Beginner	type1, 2, 4
P9	Female	30-39	Bachelor's	Nutritionist	Beginner	type 2, 4
P10	Female	50-59	Bachelor's	Teacher	Beginner	type2
P11	Female	30-39	Master's	Psychological Counselor	Beginner	type2-4
P12	Male	40-49	Master's	Business Operator	Intermediate	type2
P13	Female	70-79	Basic	Worker	Novice	type2, 4
P14	Male	40-49	Associate's	IP Specialist	Beginner	type2

3.2 Data Collection: Semi-structured Interviews

We conducted semi-structured interviews to explore how people envision crafting and sustaining identity in AI Afterlife. At the beginning of each session, we introduced the study's goals, provided examples of everyday narrative practices, and briefly explained recent advances in generative AI for simulating humans. This framing helped participants situate themselves within broader socio-technical trends. We then presented the definition of AI Afterlife (see section 1) as a conceptual system designed to simulate oneself by drawing on selected aspects of the self such as values, goals, and life stories. To make this concept concrete, participants were explicitly instructed to imagine the system in the form of a conversational chatbot that represents themselves (not others) and to consider interactions occurring posthumously.

Narrative identity emphasized how identity work involves both selectively reconstruction the autobiographical past and imaginatively projecting into the future, situated within relational contexts [48]. Guided by research questions (see section 1) along with theoretical insights [48], we designed an interview protocol with three parts as below.

- First, we examined *identity crafting*. We began with inviting participants to share representative life stories that define who they are. We then asked how they might reflect and curate a coherence self across past and future, if creating an AI Afterlife (e.g., selection, boundaries, curation time, organizational logic, tools).
- Second, we explored *identity continuing*, prompting participants to consider how their identities might be projected and sustained posthumously through AI Afterlife (e.g., preferred narrative forms, contextual flexibility, temporal evolution and governance, responses to sensitive topics).
- Finally, we investigated *relational dynamics*, asking how identity crafting and continuing may be shaped by relationships (e.g., balancing expectations, managing access, personalizing narratives).

The protocol was designed to be inclusive, accommodating participants with diverse background. Follow-up questions were asked when compelling points or relevant experiences arose to elicit richer detail and concrete examples. To support participants in recalling personal stories in the first part, we provided optional scaffolds when needed: (1) eight life stages from Erikson’s developmental model (e.g., adolescence, middle adulthood) [16], offering a chronological frame to help participants recall across the life course; and (2) intuitive narrative prompts based on McAdams’ life themes (e.g., agency, meaning-making) [48], providing interpretive lenses for articulating meaning in their stories.

All interviews were conducted remotely via video or phone calls by the first author, lasting approximately 60 minutes each. Participants received a \$15 USD honorarium. All sessions were audio-recorded and transcribed verbatim in Chinese.

3.3 Data Analysis: Thematic Analysis

We applied thematic analysis [5] to analyze all the interview data using an inductive approach [69]. Data collection and analysis proceeded iteratively. Interviews were transcribed using a speech-to-text tool and manually reviewed for accuracy. Two authors independently coded the transcripts in Google Documents, followed by weekly meetings to reconcile differences, refine the codebook, and ensure alignment with the study objectives [12]. This process enhanced inter-coder consistency and analytic rigor.

Interviews were conducted in batches of three to four participants, with thematic saturation assessed continuously. Saturation was deemed achieved when the final batch of interviews generated no new themes [25]. After finalizing the initial code list, we synthesized related codes into overarching categories. Through successive rounds of discussion and refinement, we developed a thematic map capturing three primary themes: *crafting identity*, *continuing identity*, and *relating identity*. These themes are presented in section 4 with representative quotes translated from Chinese.

3.4 Ethical Considerations

We obtained ethical approval from the Ethics Committee of the authors’ institution for all procedures involving human participants. In addition, we sought feedback from peers both within and outside our faculty to validate the ethical considerations of the study and refine the interview procedures and questions to minimize potential discomfort.

Prior to each interview, participants received a detailed overview of the study’s aims and background, followed by an informed consent process. The consent form made clear that data would be used solely for research purposes and that participants could decline to answer any question or withdraw from the study at any time without losing compensation.

We took deliberate steps to safeguard participants' autonomy, emotional comfort, and privacy. Because the interviews were conducted remotely, participants were encouraged to select a private and comfortable setting. Participants were reminded to share only what they felt comfortable disclosing and could withhold details at any time. All data were anonymized using pseudonyms (e.g., P1), and no personally identifiable information was retained.

4 Result

We present the results around three main themes: crafting identity, continuing identity, and relating identity, along with detailed subthemes and representative quotes. An overall framework of our findings can be found in Figure 1.

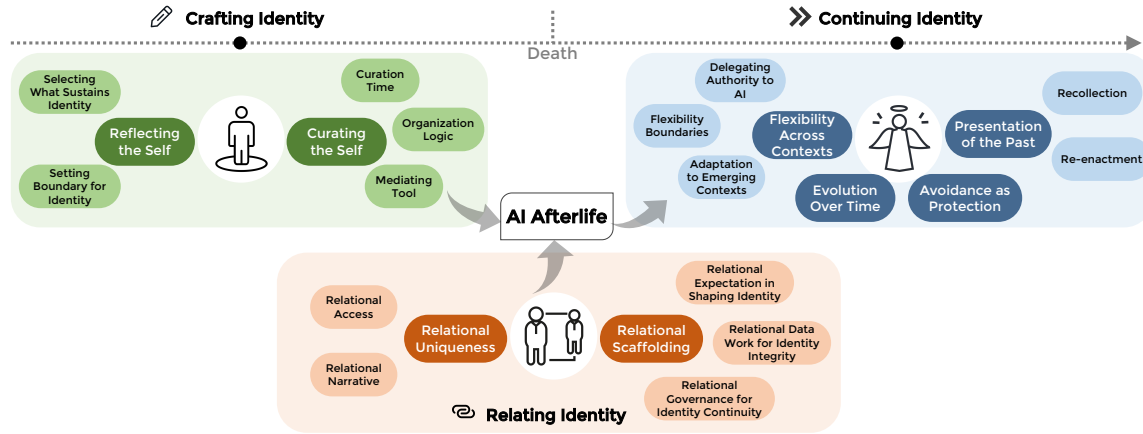


Fig. 1. The framework of our findings on identity work that transcends death in the context of AI Afterlife. The figure illustrates three overarching processes: *crafting identity*, *continuing identity*, and *relating identity*, with associated main themes and subthemes shown in bubbles.

4.1 Crafting Identity in AI Afterlife

When imagining AI Afterlife, participants engaged in crafting a coherent sense of self across two interrelated dimensions. First, they *reflected* on identity by revisiting autobiographical pasts and envisioning futures, often discovering what they considered most central to sustain identity and draw boundaries for identity. Second, they *curated* the self through organizing and recording practices to sustain identity.

4.1.1 Reflecting the Self. We first examined how participants reflected to make sense of the self, through both selecting what to include that sustains identity, and drawing boundaries around what to exclude for identity.

Selecting What Sustains Identity. Participants spotlighted which aspects of life could best represented the self and be valuable in the future, along with weighing the desire for a complete representation, to make sense of “who am I”.

Most highlighted selective moments and values that represent the self. They returned to key episodes in their lives that crystallized “who am I”, using them to articulate stable values and enduring traits. As P4 noted that “*what I have chosen has played a significant role in shaping my outlook on life, values, and worldview.*” Some emphasized formative environment and hardships during childhood or career development that demonstrated positive values (P1-2, P5). Interpersonal ties and social commitments were also central to sustain their identity. P9 stressed family bonds “*do*

not fade with time”, while P12 reflected his efforts in maintaining a happy family as an important part of himself. P5, P7, and P11 highlighted their social responsibility through community activities, brave acts of saving lives, and international voluntary teaching experiences respectively. P8 also engaged in counterfactual reflection of regretful life parts, imagining letting AI Afterlife simulate “*paths not taken*” and flipping it into part of legacy.

Moreover, they made choices with the future in mind, anticipating future interaction and value. A strong theme was education and guidance for descendants, such as “family root” and good characters. P5 explained “*if my grandchildren face difficulties, it helps them to learn how I handled mine*”. P12 and P13 stressed even failures should be shared as life lessons. Others highlighted daily companionship. P6 imagined sharing “*silly daily moments*” mattered in family. Thus, for most, the self is sustained through selective self presentation and future value, like “*the big frame, with edges*” (P7).

Despite that, some insisted on preserving the complete life to ensure AI simulates “*the true self*” (P14). P4 remarked, “*I’d put in as much as I could, otherwise it feels incomplete*”. P12 noted, “*it [AI Afterlife] should have a complete life experience and be able to simulate my cognitions and emotions to a high degree...*” P11 pointed out the limitation, “*The self has very complex structures, and many things are hidden in our subconscious*.” For these participants, even when certain key life events were highlighted, presenting only part of the self was insufficient to sustain their identity.

Setting Boundary for Identity. Participants considered authenticity, meaning-making, risk management, and the adaptation for different purposes when drawing identity boundaries, to confront the question of “where to stop”.

Most preferred curating a selective or more positive self. P10 explained, “*it should be encouraging, not depressing*.” By contrast, some argued that an authentic identity required including even private or negative aspects. P9 noted that “*various emotions and privacy belong to the real me*”. P11 echoed that integrating “*shadows*” made the self more like a human, noting “*pure goodwill comes across as one-dimensional*”. P12 put it bluntly, “*without emotions and desires, it’s just a cold machine*.” P6 also rejected “self-glorification”, warning against over-idealization.

For some, however, the question was not simply whether something was true, but whether it was meaningful, as P7 proposed that the criterion should be “*whether it benefits others*.” P1 excluded sexual experiences as “*meaningless privacy*”. P13 echoed with the privacy aspect but highlighted negative but meaningful life lessons should be included.

Moreover, boundaries also served as risk management, aimed at avoiding exposing weaknesses, or causing harm and stigma. P1-2 discussed potential negative impacts brought from shortcomings or frustration. P3 shared, “*I am timid and have no sense of adventure. I won’t talk about this*”. P2 suggested including only episodes he had already overcome, noting, “*if I’m still in the valley, I wouldn’t want to talk it*.” Some also positioned exclusion as an ethical act of care, shielding both self and others from renewed trauma or shame. P8 excluded emotionally traumatic stories. P11 stressed omitting content that inflicted harm on others. P5 similarly worried that, “*dark sides shouldn’t be passed to descendants*.” However, such boundary of concealment could potentially reproduce shame if certain facts were later revealed. P7 questioned the objectivity of curation by self, noting, “*it’s just self-packaging. My children might be better judges*.”

Despite that, boundaries were also shaped by purposes. P4 envisioned setting boundaries for various uses, such as a “memorial version” of AI Afterlife might be idealized, while a “decision-support version” should strive for completeness.

In summary, reflection presents a dual process: making sense of the self across the past and the future, and negotiating what ought to be left out. Through this interplay, participants articulated how identity could be crafted to appear authentic, meaningful, and responsible, shaping by both what is narrated and what remains silenced.

4.1.2 *Curating the Self.* We then examined how participants anticipated the practical work of curating the self that could later contribute to an AI Afterlife system: deciding when to curate, how to organize, and through what tools. Here curation referred to not only recording or documenting materials, but also broadly arranging or organizing them.

Curation Time. Participants differed in when they envisioned engaging in curation: some deferred it to late life, while others emphasized the value of daily curation alongside practical limitations and the catalyst role of AI Afterlife.

Some saw curation as a task for late life, when daily obligations had passed. P1 and P3 perceived their main roles at current life stages were to develop self and contribute to family; thus there was no much time for it. Others likewise admitted they felt unmotivated now, preferring “*living in the present*” (P7) or deferring until “*on the deathbed*” when an impulse might arrive (P12). In their imagination, late life slowed down and space for reflection would open. P3, for example, expected curation to be relaxed and informal in late-life, “*just writing down scattered things, whenever I want.*”

In contrast, most recognized the irreplaceable values of daily curation. Daily practices were not only functional, but also expressive and reflective, sustaining a sense of continuity across past, present, and even the future (P5, 11). P11 described how new events could trigger connections with earlier life stages, and writing these down enabled such links to be preserved. P14, however, emphasized different mentality at different life stages impacted integrity of curation. He noted that “*if I were to record my daily life now, I’d simply record my life truthfully. Otherwise, if I were to look back and sort it out later, I would filter it with considerations like whether I am successful or its impacts on others.*”

Moreover, without daily efforts, curation would be limited by practical constraints in late-life. Some mentioned memory fading (P9, 11), lost details or feelings (P2, 10), and energy limitation (P4-5). P4, who kept a diary, reflected on how limited time force people to allocate attention unevenly across memories. He noted that “*people may revisit distant events less frequently not because they are forgotten, but because time itself is reallocated toward newer experiences.*” In particular, considering the uncertainty of life (e.g., accidents), there might simply be “*no time left*” for late-life (P8, 13).

Furthermore, the possibility of AI Afterlife seemed become a catalyst for daily curation. For example, P5 had never considered daily curation before but, once introduced to AI Afterlife, felt motivated and shared that “*everyone would want that*”. P6 imagined curating immediately, starting with past events and continuously adding new experiences. P10 further shared that it reduced the fear and suffering of death, prompting her to keep a diary. Therefore, the imagined technology has the potential to reshape everyday practices actively.

Organization Logic. Participants described two modes to organize memories to record or arrange existing materials, including timeline and thematic approaches, considering continuity, objectivity, meaning-making, and sustainability.

Most participants favored chronological structures, segmenting life into stages or milestones to ensure continuity and objectivity. Some highlighted life continuity through timeline structure. P5 compared this process to a “*life resume*”, highlighting meaningful achievements at different stages. She explained that “*each stage can spread positive energy to future generations.*” P9 emphasized that “*timelines can help with better recall and organization.*” Others highlighted the objectivity of organizing under a timeline, arguing against pre-defined themes or labels (P4, 12, 14). P4 explained that “*the only variable is time.*”, P12 noted that “*otherwise there will be some trade-offs, or it will be incomplete.*”

In contrast, some preferred thematic organization, emphasizing thematic meaning-making. They linked memories, such as responsibility (P3) or friendship (P2), across life stages. P2 elaborated that “*if I organize it by time, it might be uneven... I would skip a relatively dull period. Instead, organizing by themes can better highlight what I want to record.*”

P10 questioned the value of purely timeline-based organization, pointing out that *“the timeline method only lets others know the process of your life, but the theme method can make them gain more or less without wasting time.”*

Moreover, some warned that sophisticated organization designs could hinder sustainable curation. P11 suggested a hybrid way: *“I prefer to write down whatever comes to my mind every day. When I review it, I can add some themes to it.”*

Mediating Tool. Participants mentioned diverse tools for curation, from traditional diaries to social media and AI-based assistance, shaped by simplicity, familiarity, authenticity, sustainability, and efficiency considerations.

Some insisted on traditional approaches, such as handwritten diaries, voice recorders, photos, and video. P11 valued handwriting for its immersive presence, but distinguished it from complicated formats like bullet journals. P2 preferred simple recording devices that captured thoughts without any feedback, preserving *“the original self”*. P7 and P9 referred to videos as familiar forms of life documentation, with P9 adding, *“such media were convenient for later review.”*¹

Some relied on social media as lightweight tools for everyday curation. P5 described WeChat Moments² as a way to mark meaningful moments, while P8 shifted from early diaries to short videos. P5 noted that *“when I post to Moments, I am actually recording the important things in my life...”* (P5) While social media offered convenience and immediacy, its affordances were also debated, as its selective and performative nature was seen as ill-suited for comprehensive life recording. P9 noted that, *“moments is used for socialize, which may not reflect the continuity and wholeness of me”*.

Moreover, many participants regarded conversational AI as the most convenient tool for both daily and late-life curation. Curation through talking to an AI agent could reduce efforts (P6, P13), increase efficiency (P12, 14), and avoid burdening family members (P10). P6 shared that *“I don’t have a diary. Everything is in my head. But having AI should make it easier. I can talk to it every day to record everything.”* However, preferences differed in collaboration patterns with AI. Some preferred interactive assistance (P1, P6), whereas others valued minimal intervention from AI to preserve authenticity of recording content (P2, P8). P1 emphasized the importance of retaining personal control, asserting that *“I am the one who makes the final decision [about what to record].”*

In summary, curating the self unfolded across temporal rhythms, organizing logics, and mediated tools. Curation thus emerged not simply as mere documentation but as an ongoing negotiation of identity: anchored in personal preferences, practical considerations, yet mediated by existing tools and the possibilities of AI Afterlife.

4.2 Continuing Identity in AI Afterlife

When envisioning how identity would be projected and continued through AI Afterlife, participants emphasized four aspects with technological mediation. They considered how AI Afterlife should present the past, adapt across contexts, evolve over time, and defend in sensitive contexts, while remaining anchored in core commitments.

4.2.1 Presentation of the Past. We unpacked two modes of presenting the past in AI Afterlife: recollection, focusing on authenticity and the natural vagueness of memory, and re-enactment, seeking vividness and resonance.

Recollection. Participants who imagined presenting the past as recollection in AI Afterlife, highlighted authenticity and the naturally fading memory. Rather than detailed reconstruction, it mirrored how memory functions in late life.

¹Note that different mediating tools can introduce multimodal data. In this paper, we primarily focus on conversational chatbots as the technical form for exploring participants’ narrative identity (see Section 3). At the same time, we welcomed and documented participants’ feedback on multimodal curation, as such media point to a broader vision of AI Afterlife, one that may express identity through multiple modalities beyond language.

²Moments is the built-in social networking feature of WeChat, where users share daily updates (e.g., text, photos, links) with their contacts.

Some participants emphasized the importance of maintaining the authenticity of narrative. P1 argued that the self should be conveyed through broad outlines rather than fabricated specifics, noting, *“describing the general outline is enough. I cannot recall all the details, so if the AI makes them up, isn’t that just fiction?”* P7 and P8 likewise stressed fidelity to one’s own recollections. P8 noted that *“my descendants can know my real life in this way.”*

Others emphasized authenticity of the form, aligning digital presence with the natural fading of memory in older age. P4 remarked, *“if the AI talks endlessly about youth, it would be strange. Instead, a slightly faded and vague state is actually what an elder should have.”* Recollection-like presence was also imagined as intertwined across ages. P11 envisioned an elder narrating the past while weaving together experiences from other life stages.

Re-enactment. Participants who envisioned presenting the past as re-enactment in AI Afterlife, portrayed their digital presence as vividly alive across life stages. This helped sustain continuity and resonate with future generations.

Some participants described this in highly vivid terms, likened to films or time-travel. P3 noted, *“just like documentary-style memories of childhood or youth. If it could restore real life clearly, it would feel as though I were still living in reality, not just leaving behind a vague legacy.”* P6 and P9 similarly imagined a “time-travel-like” experience. P9 shared, *“I hope it could travel back to that age stage.”* For them, clarity sustained experiential continuity. Within conversational chatbot scope, such clarity would mainly be conveyed through style, details, and even personalities, as if earlier selves were having *“a real conversation”* (P14). However, participants’s references to “film-like” immersive experiences signal broader imaginaries of presence, which could be further amplified in future multimodal designs.

Moreover, some saw this mode as a way to resonate with future generations. P2 rejected the idea of an older narrator which sounded overly didactic. P12 and P13 emphasized relatability, suggesting that youth may accept opinions more readily from a digital peer than from an older figure. Others also imagined interacting with multiple versions of the self across life stages. P5 explained, *“when my descendants face difficulties, they could talk to younger me, which may feel more relatable. They could also see the older me to compare how different stages handle challenges.”* P10 likewise suggested that re-enactments across ages could create a more engaging, less forced experience.

In summary, presenting the past through AI Afterlife emerged as two modes: recollection-like and re-enactment-like, with diverse focuses. This highlighted a negotiation between authenticity and vividness, as well as between the form of fading memory and the aspirations for sustaining continuity and engaging communication cross generations.

4.2.2 Flexibility Across Contexts. Flexible narrative is needed in AI Afterlife for responding to various contexts while maintaining a coherent self. To unpack this, we examined how much authority participants granted to AI, how boundaries were drawn between fixed and adaptable parts, and how AI was imagined reacting to emerging contexts.

Delegating Authority to AI. Participants differed in how much authority they granted AI narratives in representing the identity, alongside adjustment by self for better performance, which potentially shaped the openness to flexibility.

Some expressed *high trust*, suggesting AI could represent them more accurately than themselves. P2 described AI as *“understanding better than humans”*. P13 likened it to *“another brain”*. For them, AI was believed to enhance rather than distort the identity. Others showed *conditional trust*, stressing that representativeness depended on whether AI narratives grounded in themselves. P8 said AI could represent him *“if it was based on my own life stories”*. P9 expected it to vividly convey the true self. For them, whether AI staying anchored to authentic input matters. By contrast, some

took a stance of *skepticism and caution*, citing hallucinations and gaps in understanding. P4 recounted frustrations with inaccurate AI knowledge, warning that “*such distortions in AI Afterlife would be unacceptable*”. P11 and P12 admitted often doubting AI’s authenticity. P11 noting, “*I am often deceived*”. For them, flexibility risked undermining credibility and was viewed with suspicion.

Some also envisioned *interactive finetuning*, where narrative authority was co-constructed through iterative correction. Some described checking, revising, and training AI responses until they aligned with intended meanings (P1, P11-12, P14). For them, flexibility was not granted outright but earned through ongoing adjustment. Despite that, P1 acknowledged, “*it would be better to just be my archivist, if it cannot simulate me even with training.*”

Flexibility Boundaries. Participants set boundaries between what should remain fixed, serving as “identity anchors”, and what could be adapted, allowing for natural and expressive interaction across contexts.

Most insisted that certain aspects of self must remain fixed, especially *facts, values, and relationships*. P1 stressed factual details such as “*year, university, workplace*” must not be modified. P5 likewise likened values and family rules to “*a textbook*” that can not be distorted. P2 and P4 warned that fabrication undermined integrity and trust of AI Afterlife.

Others acknowledged *negotiated flexibility*. Some set clear boundaries or acceptable orientations. P6 distinguished between self-recorded memories, which should remain accurate, and AI-generated conversations, which could be optimized. P3 welcomed AI’s capacity to refine his thoughts into more profound expressions. Moreover, some emphasized the need for contextual adaptation. P9 highlighted that narratives should feel natural in everyday conversation, rather than being “*templated like a robot*”. P4 similarly noted that in casual, companion-like conversations “*it was acceptable if the AI improvised.*” Stories might also be adjusted to fit shifting social norms (P10), while responses might be tailored to of audiences at different life stages (P12). However, for some, flexibility was limited to the surface level; the core content should remain unchanged. P8 and P14 both allowed AI to adjust “*style or expression*” but not modify the content.

Adaptation to Emerging Contexts. Participants emphasized AI Afterlife to adapt to unforeseen or future contexts. This helped sustain identity continuity and preserve intergenerational relevance, yet it also introduced tensions.

Some participants stressed the importance of acknowledging limitations to avoid hallucination. P4 warned that if AI lacked relevant experience, it should admit such as “*your grandfather never started a business*”. P8 argued memory gaps should be handled with explanation of forgetting rather than fabrications that could mislead descendants. Others downplayed the need for adaptivity (P7-9). P8 regarded guidance beyond lived experience held limited value.

By contrast, many viewed flexibility as essential for keeping the digital self alive and valuable. P10 cautioned that “*if it is rigid, its usefulness won’t last; in a few years people would abandon it.*” Others envisioned AI reasoning grounded in personal or family principles. P5 noted that “*when descendants ask, it should answer with the mindset of how I would handle it.*” Some also extended this to enduring moral values (P7) or collective reasoning, such as widely acknowledged practices in current society (P11, 14) or aggregated intelligence of digital selves (P12).

Yet this flexibility capacity raised tensions around responsibility, authenticity, and emotional reliance. P3 and P13 argued that advice in hypothetical contexts should be framed only as guidance, not responsibility. Others stressed the need to limit reasoning. P4 contrasted it with commercial AI, remarking, “*it should feel more like a real human, not omniscient.*” P9 likewise valued restrained reasoning, favoring simple responses that offered emotional support without overextending intelligence. She noted that “*after I pass away, my descendants should move on and live their own lives, rather than constantly interacting with my AI or developing an emotional dependence on it.*”

In summary, flexibility introduced opportunities for continuing identity across contexts, especially when it reinforced authenticity, expressiveness, and intergenerational relevance, but it could be problematic if it eroded trustworthiness, blurred responsibility, or fostered emotional dependence beyond ethical bounds.

4.2.3 Evolution Over Time. Beyond immediate flexibility, evolution refers to updates of AI Afterlife over longer horizons. To unpack this, we examined whether AI Afterlife should remain as static legacies, or how AI Afterlife could evolve dynamically over time, alongside concerns around such evolution.

Evolution Boundary. Participants grappled with whether AI Afterlife should remain a faithful legacy, or evolve as a dynamic presence, introducing updates to maintain relevance or growing continuously to enable immortality.

Some participants favored a static archive, insisting that life stories and personality should remain the same. P9 and P10, for example, preferred preserving the past without further growth. P9 noted that *“I just hope it keeps the past.”* P10 likewise claimed that *“I was originally an ordinary teacher. I don’t need it to help me evolve into a high-ranking principal.”*

Most, however, argued that without updates it would soon lose value, as P4 likened static systems to *“outdated games.”* It is similar to the need for flexibility but with ongoing updates across domains: factual knowledge (P1), socio-technical development (P2-3), and family changes (P4). P3 explained that *“it must keep up with the times to answer questions from future generations”*. Others pointed to broader adaptation, such as learning from descendants’ needs. P12 emphasized this enabled *“better understanding of habits and expectations, making conversations more efficient and sustainable.”*

Some further imagined AI Afterlives being capable of continuous growth and even immortal. P6 and P14 argued it should also learn and polish itself. P14 noted that *“that is what we are doing in daily life.”* Evolution was also seen as an extension beyond human limits. P6, P8, and P14 perceived ongoing stories written after death as part of self life. P8 noted that *“this is what immortality exactly means.”* P7 framed it as an agent sustained in social life, and P11 hoped it could *“step into places I never reached, even centuries ahead.”*

Evolution Concerns. Participants showed concerns on evolution, such as losing authenticity and fostering emotional over-reliance (similar to flexibility), alongside blurring the boundary between a digital legacy and a living person.

Some stressed retaining the original self as an anchor of identity. P1 proposed maintaining a *“baseline self”* alongside evolving versions, clearly distinguished from the initial one. P12, however, preferred the static form, arguing that exposure to external knowledge would distort the self. Others feared too much evolution would erase the line between a legacy and a living person. P4 insisted it should remain a *“tangible item or pet”* rather than develop new traits. He explained that *“if its personality can change, then it becomes a living person.”* P9 echoed this and warned that ongoing growth could foster reliance beyond remembrance. She noted *“I only want a way to remember and commemorate what is gone, not for it to keep growing.”* Thus, P9 preferred interactions based on short-term information without long-term memory, so conversations remained meaningful but avoided evolving into an ongoing relationship.

In summary, perspectives on evolution revealed a spectrum of possibilities: from static archives that preserve a faithful legacy, to ongoing updates that keep the self relevant over time, to visions of continuous growth approaching immortality. This highlights a negotiation between authenticity, relevance, and potential ethical risks.

4.2.4 *Avoidance as Protection.* Avoidance emerged when participants preferred not to surface some sensitive topics under certain contexts or with specific audiences. P11 described this as a “defensive posture”, explaining “I would include these stories in my AI Afterlife as they shape other expressions; but typically I would adopt an avoidance strategy when asked.” To unpack this, we examined avoidance strategies ranging from withholding and deflecting to concealment.

Avoidance Strategies. Participants imagined various avoidance strategies, including direct refusal or explanation, indirect or evasive strategies, and concealment, shaped by concerns for self-protection and conversational flow.

Some participants preferred taking the form of *open refusals or limited explanations* to show clear attitudes. Rather than engaging fully, participants set verbal boundaries that signaled certain topics were off-limits. P3 and P8 directly signaled unwillingness. P3 envisioned her AI agent would say, “I’m not interested, I don’t want to talk about it.” P11 imagined her agent pushing back, “live your life, I can teach you how to do things, but don’t gossip about mine.” Others chose partial frankness to explain, such as “in my memory they were not that important” (P9). P11 framed avoidance as personal preferences, noting, “this feels like an epitaph; I [the AI Afterlife] will just tell them I don’t like that part of my life, so they don’t need to care.” These refusals and explanations reveal defensive strategies that preserved clarity.

Others anticipated *indirect or evasive strategies* to avoid direct confrontation while keeping conversations flowing. P2 described deliberate misalignment, noting, “you ask about A, I answer with B.” P13 suggested shifting to interesting topics. P10 favored claiming forgetfulness as a softer tactic, such as “I don’t remember”, which sustained the exchange better than outright refusal. Some reframed avoidance as moral practices. P5 offered positive guidance instead of disclosure. P12 stressed broad life lessons over specifics. Such strategies allowed interaction to continue in more controlled directions.

Some emphasized *concealment*, protecting self-image by packaging or disguising responses, treating denial as a normal social defense. P1 argued that “if you skip the topic, you are admitting it in reverse. Everyone lies. If AI cannot lie, it makes no sense.” P3 similarly suggested fabricating or downplaying experiences, noting, “just say I never went through that.” Others saw concealment as a kind of kindness. P7 remarked that “everyone has secrets, even lies can be kind.” Concealment here was less about deception than about affirming the inevitability of private boundaries.

These strategies are personalized. P4 noted that avoidance could be templated or carry personal styles, for example, “if I was gentle, I might say ‘baby, I will tell you when you grow up’; if humorous, I might simply pretend I forgot.”

In summary, avoidance highlights that sustaining identity is not only about what is expressed and preserved, but also about the selective withholding and reframing of information. These strategies protect self privacy and dignity, while keep conversations sustainable and meaningful.

4.3 Relating Identity in AI Afterlife

When envisioning AI Afterlife, participants emphasized that identity was not only individual but also relational, shaped by diverse access and narrative, formed and sustained through relational scaffolding.

4.3.1 *Relational Uniqueness.* We examined how AI Afterlife systems distinguished relationships through access control, balancing openness and restriction, and through narrative that emerged as uniform or differentiated.

Relational Access. Echoing prior work on audiences in AI Afterlife [44], our participants expressed divergent views on who should be able to interact with their AI Afterlives, revealing a tension between openness and restriction.

Supporters of openness framed it as a way to sustain ongoing presence of the self. Some imagined granting access broadly, even to strangers (P5, 10, 12, 14). P5 remarked “*just like real life.*” P6 suggested keeping polite greetings for strangers, since otherwise “*you seem to be a frozen screen*”, while deeper questions could be declined.

Others favored strict limits based on relational closeness, allowing only close family or trusted friends (P1-3, 7-9, 13). P2 stressed subjective preference, allowing only those they felt close to, describing the access right as “*a boundary, a separation.*” P3 likewise argued that strangers had no grounds for conversation, noting, “*you wouldn’t randomly talk with a stranger who has nothing in common with you.*”

Relational Narrative. Participants reflected on if AI Afterlife should narrate uniformly or adapt across relationships, weighing simplicity and relief against plurality as a mark of humanity and authenticity, alongside concerns.

A minority of participants preferred uniform expression for simplicity and as a gesture of relief. P7 regarded narrative tailoring as an unnecessary burden, noting, “*it’s too troublesome. Once you are gone, there is nothing left to hide or resent.*” P12 echoed and favored a single “general version” so descendants could receive a consistent picture, stating, “*in life I already went through those distinctions. Why repeat them in digital form?*”

Most, however, viewed adaptive variation as natural and desirable. P2 noted that differentiated voices would not make him feel inconsistent. P4 highlighted the inevitability of multiple roles, noting, “*to your father you are a son, to a student you are a teacher... one inevitably narrates differently.*” P1 and P14 echoed, with P1 saying, “*AI should know the difference.*” Others framed such differences as signs of vitality and humanity. P5 argued, “*different answers, tones, and styles only make the digital person more real, more humane.*” P6 extended this to situational nuance, suggesting that adaptive responses based on context add liveliness. P11 saw plurality as reflecting “*the complexity of being human.*”

Those who supported relational tailoring stressed careful design. Some imagined selective disclosure to protect privacy and dignity. P1 argued that while all memories should be preserved, disclosure must vary. P11 proposed a relational scale to adjust narrative depth. P10 suggested adjusting details depending on specific audience. Beyond protection, others emphasized personalization as sustaining intimacy, for instance, tailoring to interlocutors’ personalities (P3), attitudes (P4), or shared memories (P5). P5 added that even a identical question might need different answers to avoid harm, explaining, “*you cannot answer bluntly if it hurts someone.*” P9 and P13 likewise stressed that relational adaptation fosters sustainable, considerate communication.

Yet these visions were tempered by concerns over feasibility and ethics. P1 warned that if AI fails to distinguish relationships convincingly, distinctions may create an uncanny “*zombie-like impersonation*”. P4 doubted whether systems could ethically and technically manage such nuanced selectivity, noting it involves “*algorithms, product design, even social order.*” P8 worried about honesty, questioning whether inconsistency across relationships might appear deceptive, stating, “*we already worry about this in life. How would it work after death?*”

In summary, identity in AI Afterlife is relationally situated, negotiated through who is granted access and how narratives are shaped across relationships. This revealed tensions between openness and restriction, uniformity and differentiation, alongside concerns over feasibility and ethics.

4.3.2 Relational Scaffolding. We further examined how identity work in AI Afterlife is embedded within relational scaffolding, encompassing the balancing of expectations, collaborative curation, and intergenerational governance.

Relational Expectation in Shaping Identity. Participants reported tensions between self-authenticity and relational accommodation, including non-negotiable authenticity, selective adjustment, and the prioritization of family comfort.

For most, authenticity took precedence. P2 and P7–9 emphasized that narratives must reflect their personalities and experiences, not others’ demands. P2 stated, “*reflecting myself is more important*”, while P7 added, “*it’s meaningless to try to satisfy everyone*.” P8 even claimed, “*I will not tell them when I create it*.” P5–6 acknowledged that while advice may be useful, others usually know less than oneself. P9 argued that “*if AI overly accommodates others’ feelings, the self will no longer exist*.” P11 contended that if others want another version, “*they should make one themselves*.” Some went further to shape afterlife narrative distinguished from self. P9 noted that, “*AI even needs to express some things that I dare not express when I am still here*.” P12 echoed and expressed a relieved attitude, noting, “*why should I bother with these troubles after deceased as if I am alive?*”

Others adopted a flexible stance, allowing selective adjustment while retaining authenticity as the baseline. P3 chose to accept comments overlooked but meaningful for descendants. P10 echoed and noted that, “*otherwise it would have no meaning for them*.” P13 would adopt good suggestions, but “*if conflicts arise, it is still based on myself*.”

A minority placed relational comfort above authenticity, but without admitting it as the true self (P1, 4, 14). P4 declared that once deceased, authority should shift fully to family, noting “*I completely 100% accept their requirements, whether creating me as sexy, or as a three-year-old. I’m gone, why should I care?*” P1 proposed family-specific variants, “*gentler for parents, sweeter for a partner*”, but only framed them as “*subspecies*” or “*toys*”.

Relational Data Work for Identity Integrity. Participants reflected on how recollection is collaboratively shaped with others, which could potentially enhance identity integrity, but also risk identity distortion if conflicts arise.

Many welcomed family and friends as co-archivists to fill memory gaps, noting that forgetting and partial perspectives are inevitable. Recalling with others could recover overlooked aspects (P2, 9, 12). P9 described self-recollection as “*just a corner, incomplete*”. Some valued self-dominance in daily recording but welcomed reminders and alternative perspectives during retrospective recall (P10–11, 14). P11 reflected that dialogues with friends revealed “*from their perspective... I realized, oh, it was like this*” though she still wished her diaries remained “*more pure... not written for others*.”

Others stressed risks that relational engagement could override personal intentions, potentially reshaping memories in ways that compromised authenticity. P1 welcomed reminders but insisted on final authority. P8 and P13 were more cautious, preferring independent construction to avoid conflict. P8 warned, “*if family builds it, they may bring their own perspectives, which could lead to clashes*.”

Relational Governance for Identity Continuity. Participants reflected on how their AI Afterlife systems should be managed across generations, such as self-rule with simplest maintenance, to shared control across generations.

Some favored self-governance, with posthumous autonomous evolution anchored in pre-set principles (P11, 14). Others echoed with intention of keeping the system automatically running but with emphasis that it would not ask their family to take care of to avoid extra burden (P7–8, 10).

Yet many envisioned shared governance to avoid identity distortion. One vision was appointed custodianship, where family or descendants maintain the digital presence under informed direction. P2 and P6 suggested giving control to a trusted person, who would follow pre-set rules or the general trajectory, ensuring authenticity is not lost. P5, for example, imagined descendants adapting the digital self to social change while preserving unalterable cultural roots.

Others proposed the mode of intergenerational adaptation, where authority gradually shifted from self to descendants. P1 described this as a staged power concession, stating, *“updating every few years at first, then with increasing frequency as knowledge turnover accelerates, ultimately requiring descendants’ governance”*. P3 and P13 also emphasized that once the individual no longer exists, *“future ideas must rely on them to infuse.”* P4 suggested layered permissions, *“initial rules set by the self, but family holding higher authority to adjust or overturn them.”*

In summary, identity in AI Afterlife emerged as a relationally scaffolded construction, formed through negotiation, curated by shared reminiscence, and sustained under intergenerational governance. It is shaped by tensions between authenticity and accommodation, collaborative enrichment and distortion risks, autonomy and relational burden.

5 Discussion

In this section, we first conceptualize identity in AI Afterlife as negotiated, dynamic, and relational, and then situate narrative identity in posthumous AI-mediated contexts. Finally, we propose design implications for supporting identity work in AI Afterlife as well as outline ethical considerations to ensure responsible identity work.

5.1 Identity as Negotiated, Dynamic, and Relational in AI Afterlife

Our study suggests that identity in AI Afterlife is not a fixed archive or static trace. Instead, it emerges as an intertwined construction, shaped through ongoing negotiation, adapted across contexts and over time, and grounded in relational uniqueness and scaffolding.

First, identity is continually negotiated across the self, AI mediation, and social relationships, as well as through the tensions people seek to balance. At the self level, participants reflected on what should be remembered and where narrative boundaries lie, and curated the self through organizing and recording (see section 4.1). In relation to AI, they negotiated mediation trade-offs: balancing authenticity and vividness in presentation, continuity and adaptability in flexibility and evolution, and disclosure and protection in avoidance (see section 4.2). Socially, they negotiated relational uniqueness and scaffolding by managing varied access and narratives across relationships, balancing expectations, and coordinating curation and governance (see section 4.3). These negotiations illustrate that identity is not a fixed essence but shaped through ongoing negotiation, such as selective and complete, authentic and vivid, continuous and adaptive, expressive and protective, and personal and relational, across multiple levels of mediation. This echoes accounts of weaving the personal and the social in traditional digital legacy (e.g., MySpace [8], Facebook [22]). Our study extends this lens to the emerging context of AI-mediated afterlife, where negotiation is complicated by interactive, generative, and evolving capabilities of generative AI that introduce both opportunities and risks.

Identity in AI Afterlife is also dynamic. Rather than a static archive, it could adapt across contexts and evolve over time. This dynamism is essential for an identity meant to endure beyond death, enabling it to respond to contextual and temporal shifts. Participants described strategies such as controlled flexibility, selective updating, presentation and avoidance to manage adaptations while preserving continuity (see section 4.2). This perspective resonates with prior work showing that digital identities are not fixed but undergo temporal shifts as they are engaged with and reinterpreted by the living [8]. Whereas these studies emphasize how practices around digital legacies evolve, our study extends this lens to the imagined context of AI Afterlife. Here, identity transcending death is expected to remain dynamic, reshaped through generative AI that not only preserves but also adapts and extends narratives of the self.

Finally, identity is consistently understood as relational. Posthumous selves are not sustained in isolation but through social ties who shape, govern, and interact with them. This social embedding encompasses both uniqueness, where AI Afterlife systems differentiate access and adapt their narration across relationships, and scaffolding, in which collective reconstruction of memories and ongoing governance support continuity (see section 4.3). Prior work on digital legacy has highlighted the social dimension of identity. For example, [10] shows how users and their loved ones collaboratively prepare digital legacy. Other studies similarly point to how continued identity is managed by trusted individuals [21, 22] and distributed across networks [9]. Our study extends this relational perspective into the context of AI Afterlife, where such social embeddings raise both opportunities for ongoing value and interaction, and consistent risks such as responsibility and emotional reliance (see section 4.2).

In summary, posthumous identity in AI Afterlife is not a passive static archive, but a continually negotiated, dynamic and relational construction, shaped by the self, technology, and social ties. This highlights how generative AI continues and even extends identity, yet complicates the contextual, temporal, and social aspects of identity after death.

5.2 Narrative Identity in Posthumous AI-Mediated Contexts

Narrative identity frames the self as “an internalized and evolving story” that people construct by selectively reconstructing the past and imaginatively projecting into the future [48]. It offers a way to understand how individuals make sense of their identities and maintain continuity over time. In our study, narrative identity is primarily used to inform identity crafting part which involves both past and future considerations (see section 3.2). Its emphasis on social embedding also guided our attention to relational dynamics in identity work. Importantly, posthumous AI-mediated contexts represent an emerging narrative space, where narrative identity perspectives have been little examined. Drawing on this lens, our findings suggest two preliminary ways that generative AI may broaden narrative identity in posthumous settings: by adding representational layers to the future-oriented dimension, and by redistributing authorship across people and technologies.

First, the “future” dimension appears broadened. Classically, the future horizon concerns personal becoming - “where I am going”, framed by plans, goals, and trajectories that sustain continuity [48]. In posthumous AI-mediated contexts, this horizon gains an added representational dimension: not only one’s own imagined becoming but also how one will be narrated after death. Participants described situations in which an AI Afterlife might present, adapt, or withhold aspects of a person’s presence (see Section 4.2). They also imagined AI systems that could continue “personal becoming” beyond biological limits: continuing to learn, stepping into new contexts, and projecting identities centuries into the future (see section 4.2.3). These possibilities challenge traditional temporal boundaries of narrative identity. As such technologies evolve, it might further invite reflection upon posthumous roles, obligations, and social functions.

Second, our results highlight distributed authorship. Whereas traditional accounts emphasize internalized, first-person authorship, AI-mediated posthumous narratives often become multi-stakeholder: the deceased’s prior curation, relational uniqueness and scaffolding, and generative AI together shape what is narrated and performed (see Sections 4.2 and 4.3). This triadic, co-authored configuration unsettles assumptions of singular, continuous authorship and points to unresolved tensions around authority, responsibility, and ethics, issues connected to prior HCI and CSCW work on co-construction and governance of digital legacies [10, 21, 22]. We therefore argue that narrative identity accounts should consider distributed, technology-mediated authorship when theorizing posthumous identity within AI Afterlife.

These observations are preliminary and limited by our sample and methods (see Section 6). They suggest a concrete agenda (e.g., posthumous narrative, distributed authorship) for follow-up work, so that narrative identity concepts can be tested and refined in posthumous AI-mediated contexts.

5.3 Design Implications for Supporting Identity Work in AI Afterlife

5.3.1 Designing for Reflection and Curation as Socio-Technical Medium. Although narrative identity develops continuously throughout life [48], previous work in digital legacy shows that practical self-curation often gets deferred until late life, constrained by limited time, energy, and fidelity [10, 70]. Our findings, however, indicate that imagining posthumous interactive agents motivates individuals not only to begin recording and organizing materials earlier (see section 4.1.2) but also to engage in reflective acts of articulating meaning, spotlighting what matters most and setting boundaries (see section 4.1.1). This suggests that AI Afterlife should not merely as storage but as a socio-technical medium that motivates and scaffolds everyday identity work. Rather than a discrete product, it should be understood as an infrastructure that gradually reshapes how reflection and curation are embedded in daily life. This resonates with Postman’s notion of “the medium as the metaphor”, in which technologies act not only as tools but as metaphors that restructure social practices and even societal arrangements [60]. Below we outline four design directions.

Support reflection as active meaning-making. As observed in section 4.1.1, we suggest systems should scaffold reflection as active meaning-making rather than mere capture. Prompts or conversational scaffolds could help surface highlighted moments intertwined with values, formative experiences, and lessons, while boundary-setting features (e.g., reminders of sensitive disclosures, options to limit scope) ensure reflection remains intentional and ethically aware.

Accommodate temporal orientations of curation. As observed in section 4.1.2, while many were motivated by AI Afterlife or perceived the benefits of daily practices, others deferred curation to late life, despite risks of fading memory, limited energy, and life’s uncertainties. To support such orientations, systems could provide both lightweight or passive tools such as automatic message archiving, background voice or video capture, or periodic prompts can encourage reflection without imposing heavy effort. In parallel, long-term structures like timeline visualizations or life-stage folders can help gradually organize materials, mitigating late-life constraints while encouraging earlier engagement.

Enable flexible curation logics across time and themes. As observed in section 4.1.2, participants imagined moving between different organizing modes: sometimes arranging materials chronologically, other times grouping them thematically (e.g., by relationships, values, or major events). They also envisioned beginning with small, fragmented entries and later reorganizing them into more coherent structures. To support this flexibility, systems could allow switching between chronological and thematic views, and by enabling layering, where brief notes can later be expanded with richer context. Such features make curation more adaptable to personalized or evolving needs and preferences.

Treat artifacts and AI as co-authors, not mere tools. As observed in section 4.1.2, we suggest diverse media and AI should be treated as co-authors rather than passive tools. Language-based media along with those beyond our primarily technical scope (e.g., handwriting, voice, photo, video, social updates) preserve presence and authenticity. Conversational AI assistants were seen as lowering the burden of recording, but must remain transparent and editable so that users retain authorship and control over how materials are structured, summarized, or inferred.

In summary, reflection and curation should be designed as ongoing, evolving practices rather than one-time documentation tasks. AI Afterlife, when conceived as a socio-technical medium, not only archives lives but also actively supports how people reflect and curate identity in the present.

5.3.2 Balancing Continuity and Adaptability in AI Afterlife. Prior work warns that AI Afterlife may risk undermining identity consistency [44]. Our findings, however, suggest that identity continuity entails not absolute stability but an ongoing negotiation between coherence in core commitments and adaptability by individuals, across contexts, and over time. Design should consider how systems stabilize key elements of self identity, yet adjust presentation modes, and provide mechanisms for flexible boundaries, temporal updating and avoidance. Below we outline four design directions.

Balance authenticity and vividness. As seen in section 4.2.1, people envisioned two complementary modes of projecting identity in AI Afterlife: recollection-like (authentic, memory vagueness) and re-enactment-like (vividness, immersion). For conversational chatbots, this tension could be reflected not as rigid modes but as stylistic variations. Recollection could be supported by styles that foreground conciseness, vagueness, or acknowledgment of forgetting, mirroring the natural fading of memory. Re-enactment could, in turn, be supported through richer details or immersive perspective-taking, or even adopting the style of earlier selves (e.g., tones, personality). Designs could let users adjust these options depending on context, for instance, shifting between recollection-like narration when seeking authenticity, and re-enactment-like narration when aiming for engagement or resonance. Such balances could extend across modalities (e.g., visual and embodied forms), potentially amplifying the tension between authenticity and vividness.

Enable contextual flexibility with safeguards. As observed in section 4.2.2, people valued adaptability to diverse situations but stressed clear boundaries around fixed elements. Designs might therefore allow flexible responses that adapt to different contexts, such as shifting style or emphasis, while also protecting certain non-negotiable aspects of identity from alteration, such as factual life events or core values. One potential approach is to draw on personal archives or family materials when generating responses, and further presenting key anchors through mechanisms that preserve verbatim materials or immutable anchors alongside generative outputs. In this way, AI Afterlife could remain responsive in tone and detail across situations without compromising the integrity of the self it represents.

Balance temporal relevance with continuity. As discussed in section 4.2.3, AI Afterlife may need to incorporate new knowledge, social change, or family stories to remain meaningful. Yet participants cautioned against over-extension, where the AI might evolve into something resembling an autonomous persona that risks emotional reliance or identity distortion. One way to balance this tension is through versioning update mechanisms that make visible when and how changes occur. Designs could also consider adopting differentiated memory horizons: some interactions may foreground only recent or session-based information to create a commemorative and finite feel, while others may store and draw on long-term archives to sustain relevance. These mechanisms help preserve a stable “baseline self” while still allowing the system to remain current and resonant.

Respect boundaries through avoidance. As seen in section 4.2.4, avoidance emerged as a key strategy for protecting dignity and privacy. Silence or refusal should not be treated as system failure or shortcomings but as a deliberate design choice. Systems could offer configurable avoidance strategies, including silence, redirection, explanation, or explicit signaling that a topic is off limits. These strategies could be tailored to personal style and different contexts, ensuring adaptability also includes the right to withhold.

In summary, these implications frame identity in AI Afterlife as a balance between holding on and letting change in. Designing AI Afterlife thus entails sustaining a baseline self while enabling negotiated adaptability across contexts and time. This reframing positions identity not as fixed preservation nor as limitless expansion, but as an ongoing balance, one that requires careful socio-technical mediation.

5.3.3 Designing AI Afterlife as a Relational System. Existing research and commercial systems [3, 68] largely preserve static digital legacies, but this often leads to generic interactions that neglect contextual and relational dynamics [39]. Our findings suggest instead that identity in AI Afterlife is inherently relational: it takes shape through expectations, data work and governance as well as through differentiated access and narration. Rather than treating AI Afterlife as an isolated replica, designs should embed it within relational dynamics. Below we outline three design directions.

Establish identity recognition. As discussed in section 4.3.1, systems should provide mechanisms that recognize relationships and use them as the basis for access and narration. Depending on device capabilities, this recognition

could rely on biometrics or other contextual signals. Such recognition ensures that AI Afterlife remains socially situated and avoids collapsing diverse audiences into a single, generic persona.

Support relational differentiated narrative. As observed in section 4.3.1, systems should allow narratives to adapt to different audiences. This involves configuring relational attributes, such as relationship closeness, shared memories, or personal preferences, and curating relationally tagged content with adjustable boundaries. Features such as restricted access or layered disclosure help modulate narrative details, balancing authenticity with personalization and protection.

Enable multi-level engagement and evolving governance. As highlighted in section 4.3.2, AI Afterlife should enable identity to be co-shaped and responsibly managed over time. For authorship, systems could allow individuals to invite family members or close others to contribute memories, stories, or media, while still ensuring that the represented person retains ultimate control over what is included. This approach frames AI Afterlife as a multi-user collaborative platform, with the represented individual serving as the primary controlling user. For governance, systems could provide staged controls: initially granting the individual full authority, later enabling trusted others to assume responsibility, and eventually allowing family members across generations to sustain this process. Design features such as role-based permissions, edit audit trails, and options for gradual transfer of control can help balance personal integrity with shared continuity, while also reducing risks of rigidity or conflict.

In summary, AI Afterlife should be designed as a relational system that recognizes relationships, curates differentiated narratives, and sustains identity through multi-user, multi-level engagement and governance. Such designs move beyond static preservation toward socially embedded and evolving practices of identity work that transcends death.

5.4 Ethical Considerations

While AI Afterlife technologies offer opportunities for preserving memories and extending identity beyond death, they also raise profound ethical concerns. A central risk lies in the potential misuse of such technologies. For instance, individuals with harmful or extremist ideologies could employ AI Afterlife systems to perpetuate their influence posthumously, thereby prolonging the reach of destructive ideas and potentially legitimizing harmful legacies. Similarly, corporations, governments, or other powerful actors might exploit AI Afterlife to manipulate collective memory or shape social narratives, selectively curating identities in ways that reinforce political agendas or commercial interests. Beyond intentional misuse, broader societal implications emerge: Who has the right to control or authorize the continuation of a person's digital presence? How do we safeguard against identity distortion, exploitation of the deceased's persona, or unintended emotional harm to survivors? Addressing these issues requires not only technical safeguards but also governance frameworks that foreground respect for individual autonomy, relational sensitivity, and societal well-being.

In our study, we touch on some of these issues, and participants' feedback offers preliminary responses to them. However, future research on AI Afterlife system design should pay closer attention to these ethical complexities, developing strategies that ensure responsible use, minimize risks of misuse, and balance personal, relational, and societal interests.

6 Limitations and Future Work

While this study offers valuable insights into how individuals craft, continue, and negotiate relational identity in AI Afterlife, its scope is shaped by cultural and methodological constraints.

First, our participants were primarily based in China, where cultural frameworks inevitably shaped how they viewed afterlife, identity, and narrative expression. Values such as strong familial bonds [20, 61], filial piety [35, 74], and intergenerational continuity [67] strongly influenced participants' identity work, shaping their identity reflection and

curation, anticipated ways of identity continuity in afterlife, as well as relational considerations. By contrast, in more individualistic cultures, identity may be anchored more in personal expression and autonomy [34, 37].

Second, our primarily focus on a conversational chatbot format may have set aside other modes through which people imagine to curate or present their posthumous identity (see section 4.1.2 and 4.2.1). While narrative construction is central to identity work [48], multimodal and performative forms of self-expression [42], such as voice, gesture, or embodied simulation [44], may also shape how identity is projected, continued, and extended in AI Afterlife.

These cultural and modal constraints limit the generalizability of our findings, yet the core processes of crafting, continuing, and relational identity, as well as our discussion on identity work, narrative identity, and design implications hold relevance across diverse settings. This study represents an initial step toward understanding identity work in AI Afterlife. Future research should expand to more varied cultural contexts and explore multimodal forms of afterlife interaction, complementing the narrative focus of chatbot interaction with richer expressive modalities. Such extensions would not only ensure identity continuity and coherence across contexts, but also inform the design of more culturally sensitive and expressive AI Afterlife systems.

7 Conclusion

This paper presented a qualitative study of how people engage in identity work when imagining their AI Afterlives, drawing on the concept of narrative identity. Through data collection and analysis, we identified three dimensions of identity work: crafting identity through reflection and curation, continuing identity through negotiated presentation, flexibility, evolution, and avoidance, and relating identity shaped by relational uniqueness and scaffolding. We further conceptualized identity in AI Afterlife as negotiated, dynamic, and relational, and suggested how narrative identity might be refined and extended in posthumous AI-mediated contexts. Finally, we proposed concrete design implications for supporting identity work in AI Afterlife, as well as outlined ethical considerations to ensure responsible identity work to balance personal, relational, and societal interests. With the rapid development of generative AI, the widespread adoption of AI Afterlife may not be far away. We hope this work offers user-centered insights to inform the design of such technologies in real-world contexts.

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